

Dell XPS 17

Built well, performs great, but is overdue a refresh

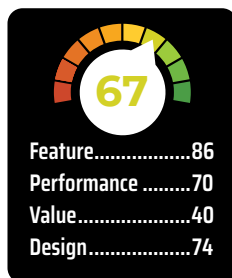
Dell's XPS series is synonymous with style, performance and a high price tag. Only sometime ago the Dell XPS 13 Plus debuted with one of the most revolutionary designs ever seen in the laptop world. An absolutely seamless keyboard, a hidden yet functional trackpad and a minimalist design were some of the highlights of the latest Dell XPS 13 Plus. However, it seems that Dell has forgotten about the other laptops in its XPS series.

The Dell XPS 17 for instance, is one such laptop that has continued to receive CPU, GPU and RAM upgrades. However, the device's overall design has remained pretty much unchanged for many years now. In 2017, Dell introduced a major overhaul to the design. Three years later, Dell updated that design with a new chassis, a larger display, a brand-new keyboard etc. Fast forward to 2023, and the overall design of the laptop remains the same. So does the laptop still remain a worthy purchase in 2023? Here's the answer.

DESIGN, KEYBOARD, TRACKPAD AND I/O

As mentioned earlier, the overall design of the Dell XPS 17 is similar to what we saw on last year's model. The 17-inch laptop has a mix of black and silver themes. The top lid has a very premium silver finish. Meanwhile, the laptop's keyboard and deck area are painted in various shades of black.

The touchpad also matches well with the overall black theme and the 17-inch size of the laptop. Which is to say, it is big and more specifically big



enough. It is a glass surface precision touchpad and works without any issues. But one issue you will notice is while lifting up the laptop lid. The chassis has no lid-opening groove so it is difficult to open the laptop. Mainly because your fingers kind of struggle to find a place to latch on to. The keyboard on the other hand works flawlessly. It uses a 60% layout but does feature navigation keys. The keys come with a 1.3mm travel and they are pretty quiet during normal operation.

Another input method on the laptop is through the 17-inch touch screen, which has a 60Hz refresh rate and is decently responsive. It also has pretty thin bezels even on the top and bottom of the screen. To put it into numbers, the display has a 93.7% screen-to-body ratio, making it highly immersive.

In terms of dimensions, the Dell XPS 17 is 19.5mm thick and it is not too thick all things considered and weighs close to 2.44kg. For comparison, the Samsung Galaxy Book3 Ultra packs similar specs but weighs close to 1.79kg. But the added weight is probably due to a touch screen and a beefed-up cooling system thanks to a massive vapour chamber.

The I/O on the Dell XPS 17 is pretty streamlined. Mainly because it features four Thunderbolt 4 USB Type C Ports, a full-size SD card slot, and a 3.5mm audio/microphone jack. But Dell also includes an adaptor with the laptop containing an HDMI 2.0 and a USB Type-A slot. Which, I must say, is a sight for sore eyes as a laptop user in 2023.

SCREEN, SPEAKERS AND WEBCAM

The 17-inch UHD+, also known as 4k, display is vivid, punchy and bright. As indicated by the "+" sign, the resolution is higher than regular 4K because the display is in a 16:10 aspect ratio and not the standard 16:9. And Dell has pulled a neat little trick here. Because from the top, the laptop looks like any other 16:9 laptop. But since it has no thick bottom chin, it can accommodate a 16:10 display. Pretty nice. I think it also prevents Dell from making this laptop any more big than it already is.

In terms of display quality and specifications, Dell has outfitted the XPS 17 with an IPS LCD panel but it is very bright. Its peak luminance came out to be 475.9nits, with 160% sRGB, 97.5% DCI-P3 and 119.1% Adobe RGB colour space coverage. Simply put, the 17-inch UHD+ display shows a wide array of colours but it doesn't showcase them accurately by default as the Delta E value came out to be 5.2. So if you're planning on using it professionally the screen requires some calibration.

The Dell XPS 17 features a quad-speaker setup including two 2.5W woofers/speakers and two 1.5W tweeters, for a combined output of 8W. And it is a pretty good setup, the soundstage is wide as you can hear a variety of instruments in any song. The bass on offer is also pretty appropriate and does not overpower the speaker's overall sound. Speakers are loud as well. For reference, I recently tested the 15-inch MacBook Air and it had a great speaker setup but the Dell XPS 17 defeated it in terms of volume and bass. But the speakers sounded clearer in higher volume on the 15-inch Apple MacBook Air.